

CSD380: DevOps

Module 7: Seeing and Solving Problems + Hypothesis-Driven Deployments and Code Reviews

Assignment 3: The Dangers of Change Approval Processes

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The Dangers of Change Approval Processes

Change management can be a useful tool for quality control and continuous, scientific process improvement. However, as with any good tool you can do some damage with it if you use it wrong. I reviewed articles about change management, and selected three which discussed drawbacks and dangers in the change approval process specifically.

LaunchDarkly

<https://launchdarkly.com/guides/reconciling-change-management-and-continuous-delivery/the-downsides-of-heavy-change-management/>

The article focused on excessive, bureaucratic change management - it's well-known that heavyhanded change management can put a lot of strain on both the team trying to implement the changes, and the regular workers just trying to adapt to it. With the approval process specifically, they cite a Google research group's report which seems to say that very elaborate approval processes tended to result in worse software delivery, and conversely good Service Delivery Optimization was associated with hitting real business targets. They also cited Forrester research showing that the long approval delays, face-to-face advisory board meetings, and manual reviews of bureaucratic change approval processes are both unnecessary and detrimental to business.

Shivam Jindal

<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/emergency-change-approvals-how-become-backdoors-shivam-jindal-ez1oc>

Unlike the previous article, this article focused on hasty emergency changes, suggesting that a very permissive change approval process can be just as dangerous as a very rigid one. If you skip the approval process for emergencies, engineers can be tempted to present desired changes as emergencies in order to expedite them and face less scrutiny about them. Not having this key quality control in the approval process can cause other breakdowns in the change process itself, like the lack of a rollback plan, or insufficient risk analysis. It can be appropriate if it's an actual emergency action triggered to protect business operations, but "emergency" needs to be tightly defined to avoid abuse.

This was an unexpected find. I definitely expected all the sources to deal with very heavy-handed processes.

Digital-Adoption

<https://www.digital-adoption.com/advantage-and-disadvantage-of-change-management/>

This article speaks more generally, but I find that the risks and drawbacks they talk about do settle comfortably on the shoulders of the change approval board.

As we all expect, gatekeeping changes behind a change approval process can be very time-consuming, and needlessly complex. It can cause friction with the team for whom the benefits of the change seem obvious - and friction with the same team for forcing changes on them that they don't want. It's hard to communicate effectively about the reasons for a change approval or denial. Most interestingly of all, your change approval board can become kind of a single point of failure, where anything that goes wrong with the board reverberates through the whole team, who can be stuck behind needed changes.

As I mentioned, sources were a bit more diverse than I expected, with a large variety of things that can go wrong. It's clear though that the answer is not no change approval; as seen above, that can be just as bad. The way through is going to be careful management and improvement of the change process itself as you go.

References

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